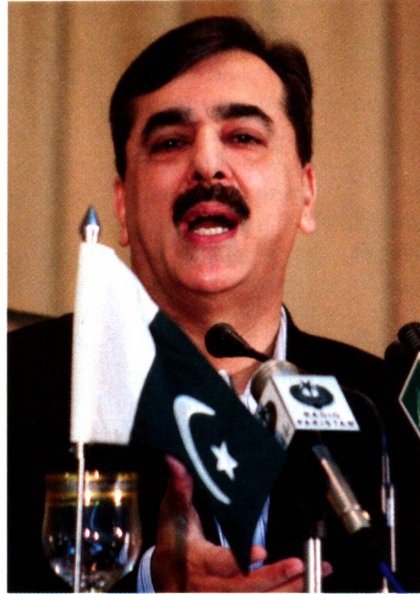


REUTERS/ANNE SEGAR

AP PHOTO/ANJUM NAVEED



ZARDARI (LEFT) MAY BE SUSPICIOUS OF GILANI'S (RIGHT) INCREASING INDEPENDENCE

WITH KAYANI REFUSING TO DEFEND ISLAMABAD AND GILANI OFFERING NO HELP, ZARDARI WAS FORCED TO CAPITULATE.

the most important politician in Pakistan today. Sharif's re-emergence on the centrestage comes at a crucial crossroads in Pakistan's turbulent history. With extremism on the rise, the Government's writ weakening, especially in the tribal regions, hardline Islamists gaining ground, terrorist attacks becoming more frequent, including a recent one on Sri Lankan cricketers, the economy in terrible shape, political parties deeply fractured and the army becoming restless, Pakistan seemed on the brink of collapse. For India, as it did for most the world, this raised all kinds of nightmarish scenarios, including of nukes falling into the wrong hands. But Sharif's heroics which led to Zardari capitulating and restoring the deposed judges has staved off a potentially explosive crisis and given Pakistan a much needed breather. Sharif attributed the victory to "peoples' power" and told INDIA TODAY that, "History is being written." (see interview). There was little doubt that in the months ahead, Sharif would be doing much of

the scripting of Pakistan's history.

The rise and rise of Sharif as a political force could not have been predicted even when he finally managed to return to Pakistan from exile in November 2007, after having been summarily bundled back to Saudi Arabia on a first attempt in September that year. He had been away from Pakistan for almost eight years, during which time most of his party had defected to Musharraf's side and the country had undergone a sea change socially—not least in the assertive independence of the electronic media. He arrived on the final day of submissions for electoral papers for the elections and with little idea of the candidates his moth-eaten party had fielded. His own nomination was rejected by the Election Commission and most analysts did not give him or his party much chance. To top it all off, Benazir Bhutto's assassination at the end of December was predicted to generate a wave of sympathy for her Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP).

But as it happened, Sharif's Pakistan Muslim

